targets, which it wanted to prioritise in the build-up to the invasion of France in 1944. All told, the bombing offensive against the German capital involved over 9,000 sorties and killed over 4,000 people. Bomber Command lost over 7,000 air crew (from a total of 55,000 airmen killed in the war – a figure that compares with 56,000 US service personnel killed in the Vietnam War).

By 1945 the USAAF was willing to join RAF raids on cities, including Berlin, and participated fully in the most controversial attack on Dresden in February 1945. There were some US commanders who opposed area bombing, but eventual acceptance of the British way in aerial warfare and the murderous bombing campaign against Japan's population, presaged US adoption of nuclear targeting strategies that envisaged wholescale destruction of the cities of the Soviet Union and its allies.

At the Potsdam conference in July-August 1945 it was agreed that after the war, Berlin would be governed under a quadripartite system comprising US, Soviet, British, and French sectors. In March 1948 the Western allies merged their sectors into a single economic area. Stalin argued this violated the Potsdam agreement and, on 24 June 1948, the Soviets began a blockade of rail, road and water communications connecting the city to the rest of the Federal Republic of Germany (FRG). Stalin's aim was to end joint administration of the city and deny the role of the Western powers.

Between June 1948 and May 1949 (when the blockade was called off), West Berlin was supplied by the USAF and the RAF with food, fuel and medicine. Some 277,000 sorties were flown. The population of West Berlin (and its peculiar political status) survived, and the city became a beacon of Western resistance against the advance of Soviet-style communism in Eastern Europe.

Perhaps nothing better symbolises the collapse of the wartime alliance against Nazi Germany and the onset of the Cold War than the roles played by the British and US air forces in these events. In less than five years the RAF had moved from trying to incinerate the population of Berlin to trying to keep it alive. There was a further and dramatic transformation during the 1950s and 1960s, when the United States, the United Kingdom, and the Soviet Union, signalled their willingness to wage nuclear war in pursuit of